

Iota Leonis
12 SunsDenebola
15 Suns

LEO THE LION

LEO IS A LARGE CONSTELLATION OF THE ZODIAC, EASY TO RECOGNIZE BECAUSE OF ITS RESEMBLANCE TO A CROUCHING LION. A SICKLE SHAPE FORMED BY SIX STARS OUTLINES THE HEAD AND CHEST OF THE LION.

Leo is said to represent the lion killed by Hercules, the strong man of Greek myth, as the first of his 12 labors. The Sickle, delineating the lion's head and chest, looks like a back-to-front question mark. At the base of the Sickle is Leo's brightest star, Regulus—the heart of the lion.

In the middle of the Sickle lies Gamma Leonis, popularly known as Algieba. This binary has two yellow-orange giants that orbit each other every 550 years. A 5th-magnitude star nearby, 40 Leonis, is unrelated. Zeta Leonis, of 3rd magnitude, has two fainter companions visible through binoculars, but the three stars are not gravitationally bound.

A number of spiral galaxies can be seen through small telescopes under the lion's body. Of these galaxies M65, M66, M95, and M96 are the most prominent.

Every November, Earth moves through a stream of particles left by the comet Tempel-Tuttle, and the Leonid meteors radiate from the region of the Sickle. Rates are usually low, but storms occasionally occur, as in 1833.

Shooting stars were said to have fallen from the sky “like snowflakes” in the Leonid meteor storm of 1833

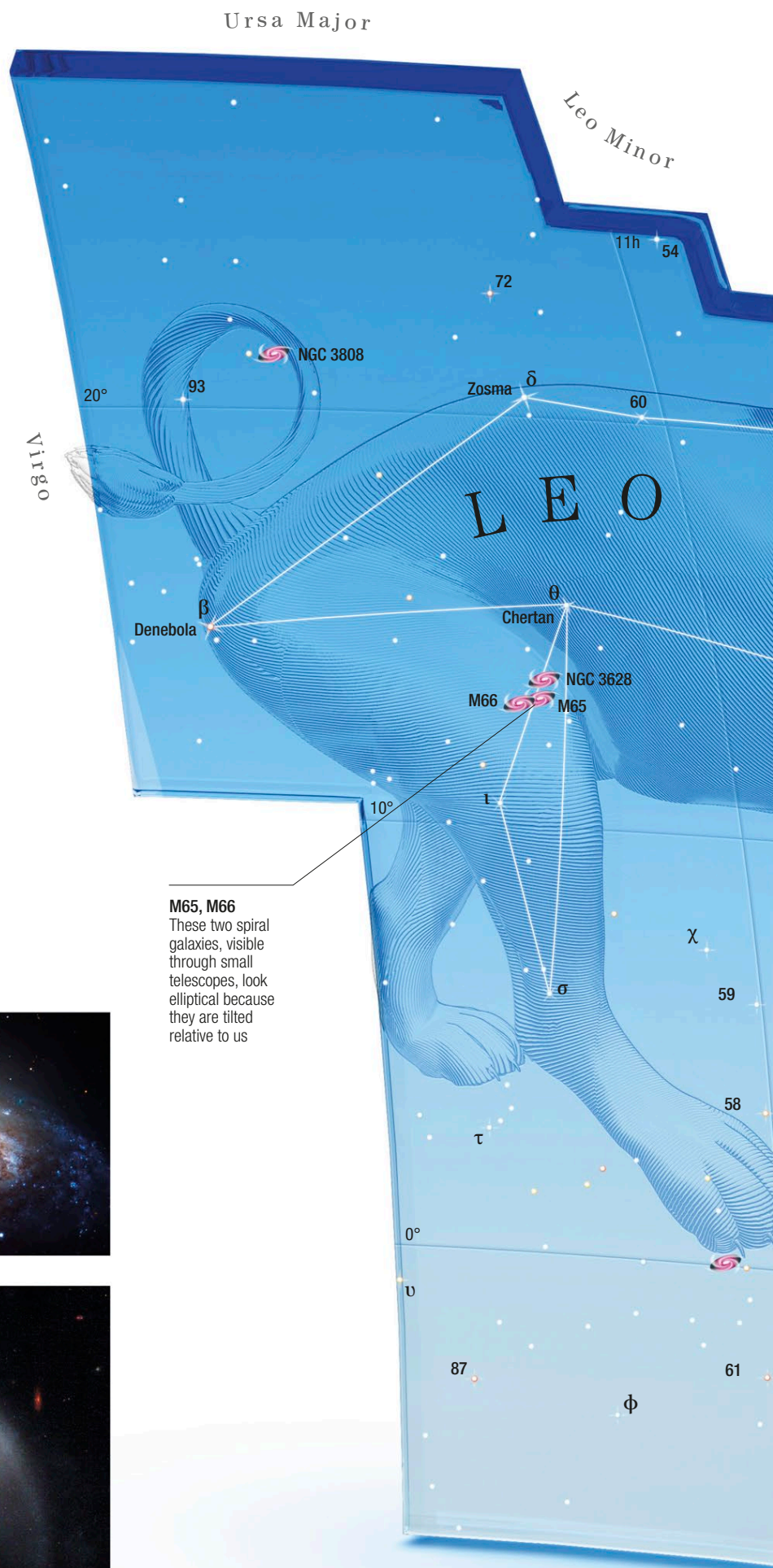
▷ NGC 3521

Patches of star formation give a mottled look to the arms of this spiral galaxy, 35 million light-years away. This image is from the European Southern Observatory's Very Large Telescope in Chile.



▽ NGC 3808 and NGC 3808A

Two spiral galaxies intertwine in this image from the Hubble Space Telescope. Stars, gas, and dust flow from NGC 3808 (right) and coil around its smaller companion, NGC 3808A (seen edge-on).



M65, M66

These two spiral galaxies, visible through small telescopes, look elliptical because they are tilted relative to us